

Photo: Ricardo Liberato, CC BY-SA 2.0

FAMILY FIELD GUIDE · V1 · 2026-10-21

Egypt

Cairo, the Nile and the temples of Luxor and Aswan

21 to 31 October 2026

How to use this guide

Every site has the same parts, so you always know where to look: **the story**, **walk it**, **don't miss**, **easy to miss**, **ask the guide**, **look closer** and **tips**.

Phone app and audio **works offline**

Audio. 11 short episodes (about 5 min) and 6 longer stories (about 10 min), read by Brian. Tap a ▶ play button in this PDF, or open the app.

Facts. Opening times, tomb access and prices change. Where the printed programme says nothing, this guide says *ask*.

Contents

Day 1	**Wed 21 Oct** Fly Paris to Cairo. Meet the Sakkara Tours representative. Hotel.
Day 2	**Thu 22 Oct** Grand Egyptian Museum. Afternoon: Dahshur (replaces Citadel, mosque, souk).
Day 3	**Fri 23 Oct** Memphis, Saqqara, Giza plateau.
Day 4	**Sat 24 Oct** Fly Cairo to Luxor. Board the M/S Monaco. Free afternoon.
Day 5	**Sun 25 Oct** Luxor Temple and Karnak. Sail about 3 h to Esna.
Day 6	**Mon 26 Oct** Edfu by carriage. Kom Ombo. Sail to Aswan. Galabeya party.
Day 7	**Tue 27 Oct** High Dam, Philae, felucca on the Nile.
Day 8	**Wed 28 Oct** Optional Abu Simbel. Sail about 7 h to Edfu via Kom Ombo.
Day 9	**Thu 29 Oct** Sail about 4 h to Luxor, through the Esna lock.
Day 10	**Fri 30 Oct** West bank: Valley of the Queens, Colossi, Medinet Habu, Hatshepsut.
Day 11	**Sat 31 Oct** Fly Luxor to Paris.

Also: Who is who · Reading a wall · Your name in hieroglyphs · Field kit · Photo credits

The route

Your route through Egypt



Flight

Nile cruise, south then back north

5 Day of the trip

Optional trip by road

Distances approximate. Natural Earth base map.

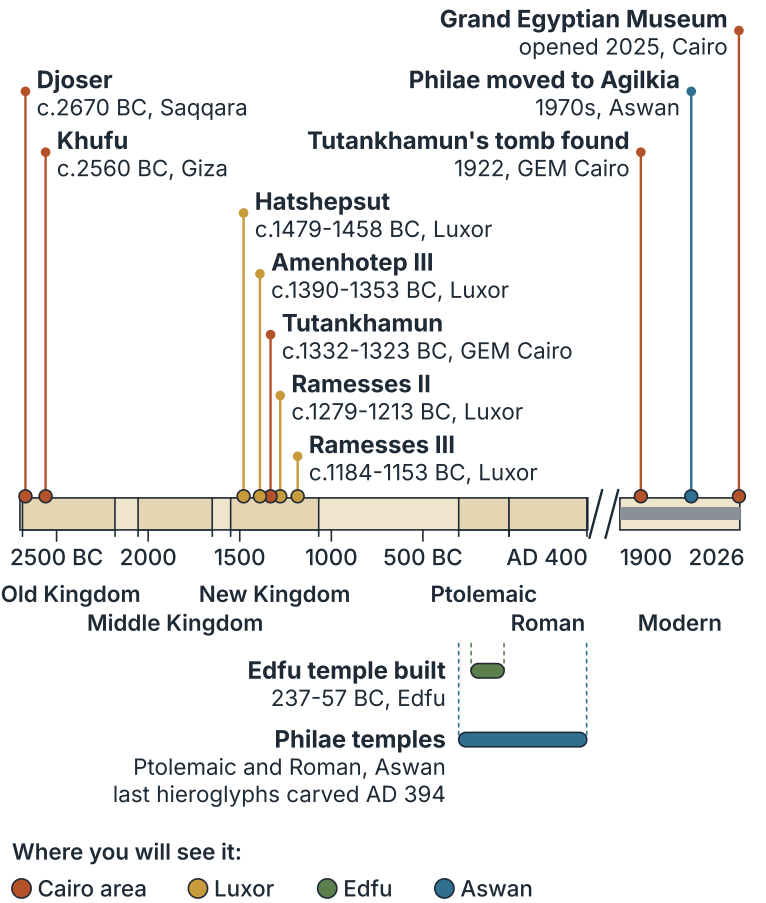
WHERE YOU SLEEP

Cairo area, 3 nights (Swiss Inn Pyramids Golf Resort or similar). Nile cruise, 7 nights on the M/S Monaco or similar. Times and order can change with the weather and local needs, as your programme says.

Three thousand years in one line

Who built what, and when

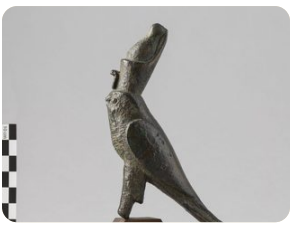
Linear scale. The axis is broken: AD 400 to 1900 is cut out.



PERIOD	YOU WILL SEE
Old Kingdom pyramid age	Saqqara, Dahshur, Giza, Memphis
New Kingdom empire and gold	Luxor Temple, Karnak, Queens, Medinet Habu, Hatshepsut, Abu Simbel
Ptolemies Greek kings, Egyptian gods	Edfu, Kom Ombo, Philae
Today	Grand Egyptian Museum, High Dam, felucca, the river

Who is who

Gods are drawn with fixed signs. Learn nine and you can read most walls.



Horus

Falcon or falcon head, often with a double crown

Sky and kingship

Edfu, Kom Ombo

Museo Egizio, Turin, CC0



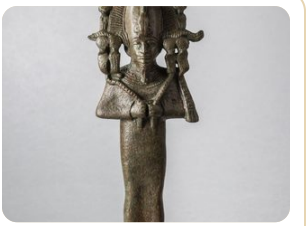
Isis

Throne-shaped crown, or a sun disk between cow horns

Magic and motherhood

Philae

Anonymous (Egypt); photograph by the Walters Art..., Public domain



Osiris

Wrapped like a mummy, holding a crook and flail

Death and rebirth

Medinet Habu, tombs

Museo Egizio, Turin, CC0



Anubis

Jackal, or a man with a jackal head

Embalming and tombs

Hatshepsut, the museum

Museo Egizio, Turin, CC0



Thoth

Ibis head, or a baboon

Writing and wisdom

Scribe scenes everywhere

The Metropolitan Museum of Art (Open Access), CC0



Sobek

Crocodile, or a man with a crocodile head

River and fertility

Kom Ombo

Museo Egizio, Turin, CC0



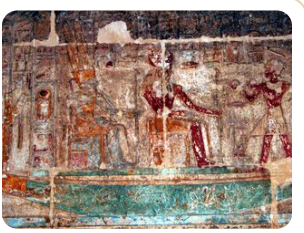
Hathor

Cow ears, or horns holding a sun disk

Love, music and the sky

Hatshepsut, Philae

Rüdiger Stehn, CC BY-SA 2.0



Amun-Ra

A man with two tall plumes, or a ram

King of the gods

Karnak, Luxor

Dennis G. Jarvis, CC BY-SA 2.0



Ma'at

Woman with an ostrich feather on her head

Truth and order

Many scenes

NeverBeGameOver, CC BY 4.0

Set, the god of chaos and storms, has an animal head no zoologist can name. You meet him at Edfu, as the enemy.

Reading a wall

1. Read into the faces. Animals and people in a line of text look toward the start of the line.

2. Size is rank. Kings and gods are big. Enemies and helpers are small.

3. Two crowns. White for the south, red for the north. Both together means the whole country.

4. The oval rope. A cartouche holds a king's name. Count how often one repeats.

5. The ankh. The looped cross is life. A god holding it to a king's nose is giving him breath.

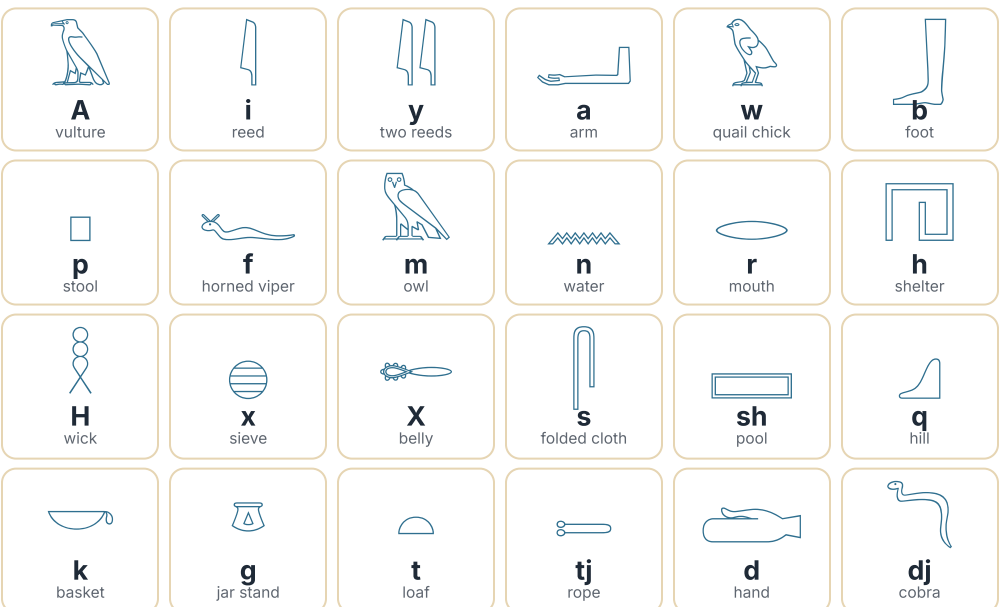
6. Colour is code. Green is rebirth, black is fertile soil, red is power and danger, blue and gold are divine.

THE SMITING SCENE

On pylons, a huge king grabs a bunch of enemies by the hair and raises a mace. It is a symbol of order beating chaos, repeated for 3,000 years. It is not a record of a single battle. Compare two of them on your trip.

Your name in hieroglyphs

Sound out your name, then pick signs for the sounds. Draw an oval around them, and you have a cartouche.



TRICKS

- There is no plain L: use the mouth sign (r).
- C is k or s. V is f. Z is s. X is k and s. O and U are the quail chick.
- Vowels are often left out. Write the consonants and add a quail chick or reed if it looks bare.
- Signs can be read left to right or right to left. Pick one direction and face the animals into the start.

Field kit

SUN AND HEAT

- Expect about 28 degrees C in Cairo and the mid 30s in Luxor and Aswan by day. Evenings are cooler, so a light layer helps on the boat deck and on the early Abu Simbel coach.
- Hats, sunglasses, sun cream, closed shoes for sand. Shoulders and knees covered is easy and sun smart.
- Plan the heavy sights for the morning. Rest on the boat in the middle of the day.

WATER AND FOOD

- Sealed bottled water only. Check the seal. Use it for teeth too.
- Hand gel before meals. Peeled fruit and cooked food are the safe default.
- Ask your doctor or pharmacist about a small kit: rehydration salts and your usual medicines.

MONEY (FROM YOUR PROGRAMME)

- Visa on arrival: 53 EUR per person, in cash euros, handled by the representative.
- Tips pool: 65 EUR per person, paid on site. Ask the representative whether children are included.
- Optional trips are paid locally. Keep small Egyptian pound notes for toilets, helpers and small tips.

PHONES AND PHOTOS

- Download the app and PDF on hotel Wi-Fi before you board. Boat Wi-Fi is paid and common areas only.
- No flash in tombs and museums. Ask the guide before using a tripod or drone, both are usually not allowed.
- Ask before photographing people. Do not photograph police or military.

RESPECT AND COMMON SENSE

- 'La, shukran' (no, thank you) said with a smile ends most sales. 'Shukran' is thank you. 'Yalla' is let's go.
- Agree any price before a ride, a photo or a favour. A 'gift' usually has a price.
- Stay close to the guide at busy sites. Agree a meeting point when you split up.

CLOCKS

- Egypt runs ahead of France by 1 hour at first, by 2 hours from 25 to 29 October, then 1 hour again. Your phone adjusts, but sailing and wake-up times are local time.

DAYS 1 TO 3

Cairo and its pyramids

Three nights near Giza. Everything below is within about 15 km of the pyramids, except the airport.

Cairo and the pyramid fields



Straight line between sites,
~ km as the crow flies (roads are longer)

Fields Town Desert

Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL)
Land cover © ESA WorldCover 2021 (CC BY 4.0)

THE PLAN

Day 2 morning. Grand Egyptian Museum, a short drive from the plateau.

Day 2 afternoon. Dahshur: the two pyramids of Sneferu. This is a suggestion that replaces the Citadel, mosque and souk. Confirm with the representative on Day 1.

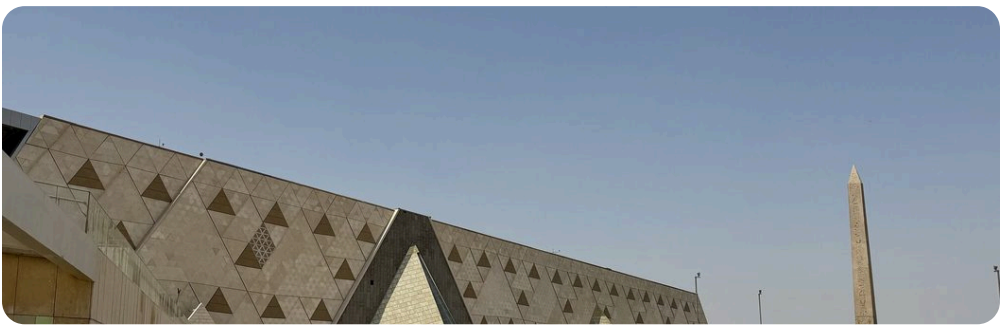
Day 3. Memphis, Saqqara, then the Giza plateau. Distances: Giza to Saqqara about 14 km, Saqqara to Memphis about 5 km, Saqqara to Dahshur about 7 km.

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DAY 2 MORNING · GIZA

Grand Egyptian Museum

The biggest archaeological museum in the world, built for one civilisation and placed about 2 km from the pyramids.



The triangle-patterned stone facade of the Grand Egyptian Museum in Giza, seen across the entrance plaza. Photo: Slyronit, CC BY-SA 4.0

PLAN	OPENED	HEADLINER
2.5 to 3 h with the guide	November 2025	All of Tutankhamun's tomb, together

The Colossus That Moved House
Short · 5 min

Tutankhamun: The Boy, the Tomb and Carter
Story · 10 min

THE STORY · THE COLOSSUS THAT MOVED HOUSE TWICE

The giant Ramesses II in the atrium was found in pieces near Memphis in 1854. In 1955 it was raised in a Cairo square, in front of the main railway station, and pigeons and traffic circled it for fifty years. In 2006 it was lifted out and trucked to Giza, and in 2018 it moved again, into the museum's atrium, before the building was even open. The statue is about 11 m tall and weighs around 83 tonnes. Tomorrow you will meet its smaller, fallen cousin at Memphis, where it was found.

WALK IT

1. Entrance plaza: the hanging obelisk of Ramesses II
2. Grand Atrium: the colossus of Ramesses II
3. Grand Staircase: statues lined up in time order
4. Top of the stairs: window onto the pyramids
5. Galleries: tombs, temples, daily life
6. Tutankhamun galleries: the whole tomb in one place
7. Khufu's boat, if on your route (ask)

DON'T MISS

Tutankhamun's gold mask. About 10 kg of solid gold. Look at the eyes (quartz and obsidian) and the vulture and cobra on the brow.

The Grand Staircase. Dozens of statues of kings, queens and gods. Walk up slowly and read the labels: you are climbing through time.

The window over the pyramids. From the top of the Grand Staircase a glass wall frames the Giza pyramids. A good moment for the family photo.

The dagger made from a meteorite. Among Tutankhamun's objects is an iron blade. Iron was rarer than gold then. Analysis showed it came from space.

The tomb in context. Carter found it crammed into four small rooms. Here the objects are spread out, so you can see how many there are: over 5,000.

EASY TO MISS

- Turn the mask around in your mind: a protective spell is written across its shoulders.
- Tutankhamun's own childhood things (a stool, small objects) sit among the grand ones. They make him a kid.
- Look for broken noses on statues. Many were damaged on purpose, to 'switch off' the statue.
- The museum is built on the desert plateau edge: look outside the glass at the sand-coloured stone.

ASK THE GUIDE

- Which objects here were found exactly where Carter photographed them, and which were moved?
- How do we know the dagger is meteoritic iron, and how did it get to Egypt?
- Why were so many statues' faces damaged, and by whom?
- What is in these halls that the old museum in Tahrir Square could not show?
- How do you decide what goes in a case and what stays in a storeroom?

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find one object made of a material that does not come from Egypt (lapis lazuli, cedar, ebony, turquoise, obsidian). Where did it come from? What does that say about trade?

Estimate. The mask weighs about 10 kg. What else weighs about that? How many gold masks fit in a backpack, and why would that be a terrible idea?

TIPS

- It is large and tiring. Ask the guide for the highlights route and agree a toilet stop before the Tutankhamun galleries.
- Rules on photography and bags vary and change. Ask at the entrance before you take anything out.

DAY 2 AFTERNOON · SOUTH OF GIZA · REPLACES THE CITADEL, THE MOSQUE AND THE SOUK

Dahshur, the two Sneferu pyramids

One pyramid that went wrong and one that worked, built by the same king. Almost nobody is there.



The Bent Pyramid at Dahshur, with the original polished limestone casing still covering its upper part. Photo: Jorge Láscar from Melbourne, Australia, CC BY 2.0

PLAN	DISTANCE	BUILT
about 2 to 2.5 h on site	about 40 km south of Giza, roughly 1 h by road	about 2600 BC, king Sneferu

▶ The Pyramid That Went Wrong
Short · 5 min

THE STORY · SNEFERU'S PROBLEM

Sneferu was the father of Khufu. His builders had already seen the Step Pyramid, and he wanted smooth sides. At the Bent Pyramid they began at a steep angle of about 54 degrees. Halfway up, with the walls cracking inside, the angle was cut to about 43 degrees. The result is the bent shape. Next to it they tried again at the gentler angle from the start. That is the Red Pyramid, the first true smooth-sided pyramid. Everything at Giza rests on these two experiments.

DON'T MISS

The Bent Pyramid's casing. It keeps more of its original polished limestone skin than any other big pyramid. This is how Giza once looked.

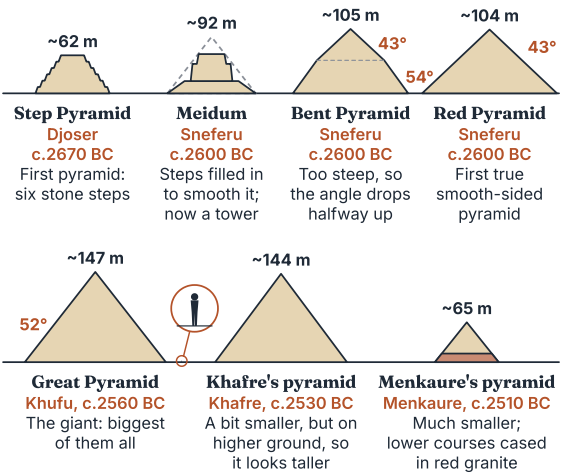
The change of angle. Stand back far enough to see the bend. It is the most honest piece of engineering history in Egypt.

The Red Pyramid's interior. A steep stair, a low passage, then chambers with stone roofs shaped like upside-down staircases. Take a torch.

The silence. No queues. You hear the wind. This is what the plateaus were like before the crowds.

A century of trial and error

Seven pyramids, side view, all drawn to the same scale



Step Pyramid
Djoser
c.2670 BC
First pyramid: six stone steps

Meidum
Sneferu
c.2600 BC
Steps filled in to smooth it; now a tower

Bent Pyramid
Sneferu
c.2600 BC
Too steep, so the angle drops halfway up

Red Pyramid
Sneferu
c.2600 BC
First true smooth-sided pyramid

Great Pyramid
Khufu, c.2560 BC
The giant: biggest of them all

Khafre's pyramid
Khafre, c.2530 BC
A bit smaller, but on higher ground, so it looks taller

Menkaure's pyramid
Menkaure, c.2510 BC
Much smaller; lower courses cased in red granite

Red circle: a 1.7 m person at the same scale (zoomed in).
Heights are original and approximate. All dates c. BC.

WALK IT

1. Arrive at the Bent Pyramid: walk the base
2. Look up: the top still wears its smooth casing
3. Drive or walk to the Red Pyramid
4. Climb the entrance stairs, if you want to go in
5. Down the long passage to the first chamber
6. Up the corbelled vault to the second chamber
7. Back outside: compare the two slopes

EASY TO MISS

- The Red Pyramid is named for the reddish tint of its stone, best at sunset.
- Look at the stone courses: they tilt inward, a trick that made the Red Pyramid stable.
- A small satellite pyramid stands near the Bent Pyramid.
- Far across the desert, the mud-brick lump of another pyramid is visible from here (the Black Pyramid, much later).

ASK THE GUIDE

- Do we know why the angle changed: a collapse, cracks, or a decision to finish faster?
- Why did Sneferu build more than one pyramid?
- How do we date these pyramids, and what do the quarry marks tell us?
- Is the interior open today, and how long is the passage?

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Photograph the Bent Pyramid from three distances. At which distance does the bend become obvious?

Estimate. The Red Pyramid is about 104 m tall. How many floors of a typical building is that? Compare it with the tallest building you know.

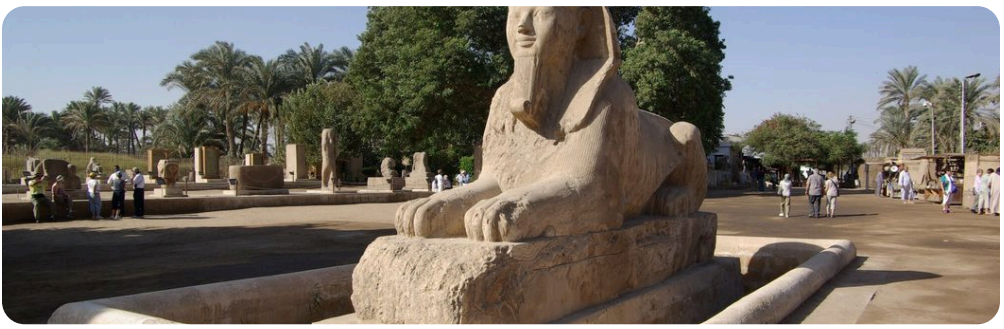
TIPS

- The inner passage of the Red Pyramid is steep, hot and low. Skip it without guilt if anyone dislikes small spaces.
- Closed shoes, hats and water. There is almost no shade.

DAY 3 MORNING · MIT RAHINA, IN A PALM GROVE

Memphis

The capital of Egypt for centuries, now a garden with a few statues. It teaches how a city can vanish.



The alabaster Sphinx of Memphis at the Mit Rahina open air museum. Photo: Berthold Werner, CC BY 3.0

PLAN	WHAT IS THERE	LOOK FOR
about 1 h	An open-air museum	The fallen colossus and the alabaster sphinx

Imhotep and the First Stone
Short · 5 min

THE STORY · WHERE DID MEMPHIS GO?

For over a thousand years, Memphis was the place where Egypt was run. The Greeks heard the name of its great temple of Ptah, Hut-ka-Ptah, as 'Aigyptos' and gave the whole country its name from it. Then the city faded, and its stones went into new buildings, many of them in medieval Cairo. One of the largest ancient capitals in the world became a field of palm trees, and then a car park for a museum. What you see is a handful of survivors.

WALK IT

1. Garden entrance and palm grove
2. The fallen colossus of Ramesses II, seen from a gallery
3. The alabaster sphinx
4. Stelae and smaller statues in the garden
5. The alabaster embalming table, if signposted

DON'T MISS

The fallen Ramesses II. It is limestone, about 10 m long, found in 1820. Compare it with the granite one you saw yesterday at the Grand Egyptian Museum.

The alabaster sphinx. Smooth, pale and over 3,000 years old. It is usually attributed to a New Kingdom king, and the face is deliberately idealised.

The sense of absence. Stand in the middle and ask yourself where the temple of Ptah, the god of builders, once stood.

EASY TO MISS

- A huge alabaster table with lion-shaped sides was used to embalm Apis bulls, sacred animals of Memphis.
- Count the cartouches on the colossus. A name in an oval rope is a king's name.
- The ground here is still rich farmland. The river has moved east over the centuries, uncovering and burying things.

ASK THE GUIDE

- Where was the ancient city, and where would the palaces have been?
- Why did we lose Memphis but keep Giza?
- What was the Apis bull, and where was it buried?
- How do archaeologists search for a city under farmland?

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find a cartouche. How many signs are inside, and can the guide read it aloud?

Debate. If a future generation found only your school's front gate, what would they conclude about your town?

TIPS

- A short stop. Shade is rare and ticket-booth souvenirs are cheap. Say 'La, shukran' with a smile if you do not want anything.



A general view of the Memphis Open Air Museum, with palms and fragments of statues and columns. Photo: ᵻᴺʔʜᵻᴺ, CC BY-SA 4.0



A standing statue of Ramesses II in the garden of the Memphis museum. Photo: Olaf Tausch, CC BY 3.0

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DAY 3 · THE STEP PYRAMID OF DJOSER

Saqqara

The first large stone building in history. Everything you will see later started here.



A frieze of rearing cobras on a wall of Djoser's complex at Saqqara, with the Step Pyramid behind. Photo: Panegyrics of Granovetter, CC BY-SA 2.0

PLAN	BUILT	ARCHITECT
about 2 h	about 2670 BC, king Djoser	Imhotep, the first one we know by name

Imhotep and the First Stone
Short · 5 min

THE STORY · A PYRAMID BY TRIAL AND ERROR

Before Djoser, kings were buried under flat mud-brick benches called mastabas. His architect Imhotep built one in stone, then added a smaller one on top, and another, and another, until it rose in six steps to about 60 m. Imhotep was remembered for centuries as a genius and eventually worshipped as a god of healing. The Greeks later identified him with their own healing god. The pyramid is a pile of experiments, which makes it the best place to understand the idea.

EASY TO MISS

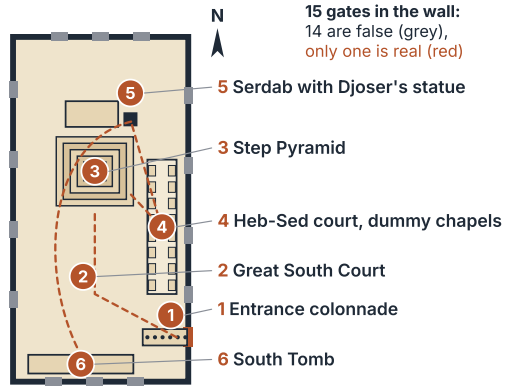
- Inside the Heb-Sed court, look for the B-shaped marker stones that outline the ritual running track.
- Notice the tiny stones used for walls: they are small blocks, like bricks, because stone building was new.
- The nearby pyramid of Unas (c. 2350 BC) is the first with writing inside. The interior is usually closed.
- Mastabas such as Mereruka and Ti have the best everyday reliefs: boats, farming, animals. Ask if one is possible.

ASK THE GUIDE

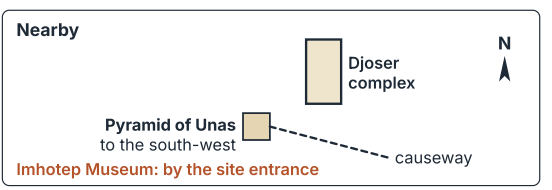
- How do we know Imhotep designed it, and what else do we know about him?
- Why six steps and not five or seven?
- What is under the pyramid? How long are the tunnels?
- Why a false door, and who was fooled?
- Which mastaba would you visit if you had one hour?

Djoser's Step Pyramid complex

Plan sketch, north up. Not to scale.



Enclosure: ~545 m north-south, ~277 m east-west.



WALK IT

1. Imhotep Museum, if time allows (ask)
2. Entrance colonnade, a covered corridor of stone columns
3. Great South Court
4. The Step Pyramid up close
5. The Heb-Sed court with its dummy chapels
6. The serdab, the sealed room with peepholes
7. Optional: Unas causeway or a decorated mastaba (ask)

DON'T MISS

The entrance colonnade. Ribbed stone columns that copy bundles of reeds. People were learning to build in stone by copying what they knew in plants and wood.

The false doors. The enclosure wall had 15 gates. Only one is real. The rest are carved stone.

The serdab. A small stone box with two holes. The king's statue sat inside to look out and receive offerings. The one here is a copy.

The dummy chapels. Solid stone buildings that look like shrines. They were made for the king's afterlife and cannot be entered.

The scale. The wall alone was about 10 m high and over 1.6 km long. Look at what is left.

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find a stone column that looks like a bundle of reeds. Draw it, then draw what you think the original building was made of.

Estimate. Djoser's pyramid is about 60 m, Khufu's was about 147 m. How many Djosers fit on top of each other to reach Khufu?

TIPS

- Sand, rubble and bright light. Wear sunglasses and closed shoes.
- Interiors of pyramids and tombs are not promised in your programme. Ask the guide what is open that day.

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DAY 3 AFTERNOON · THE PLATEAU

Giza and the Sphinx

The last of the seven wonders of the ancient world still standing. Photos hide the scale.



The Great Pyramid of Khufu seen from its base, with its stepped courses of limestone blocks. Photo: Jorge Láscar from Melbourne, Australia, CC BY 2.0

PLAN	BUILT	BIGGEST
about 2.5 h on the plateau	about 2560 BC (Khufu), 2530 BC (Khafre), 2510 BC (Menkaure)	Khufu: about 147 m originally, 138 m today

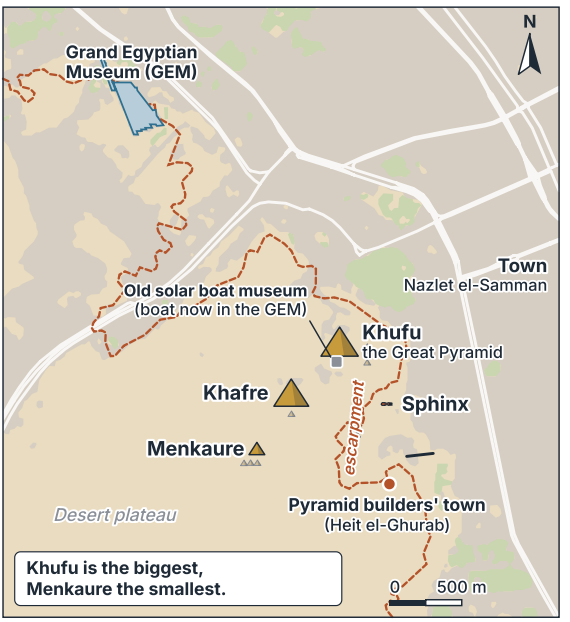
▶ Giza: Reading the Plateau
Short · 5 min

▶ Merer's Diary
Story · 8 min

THE STORY · WHO BUILT IT? MERER WROTE IT DOWN

For years people said slaves built the pyramids. Then in 2013, archaeologists at Wadi al-Jarf on the Red Sea found papyri with the logbook of a foreman called Merer. In it, he and a team of about 40 men move limestone by boat along the Nile to Giza, for Khufu's pyramid, and he notes the days they spent on each trip. They were paid, organised in crews with names, and fed. Nearby at Giza, their bakeries and cemetery have been found. The Great Pyramid was built by Egyptians who knew exactly what they were doing.

The Giza plateau



Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL)
Land cover © ESA WorldCover 2021 (CC BY 4.0)
Elevation: Terrain Tiles on AWS (Mapzen, SRTM)

WALK IT

1. Panorama point: all three pyramids together
2. Khufu: walk to the base and touch a block
3. Khafre: look for the casing still on its top
4. Menkaure: the smallest, with a gash in its side
5. The Sphinx and the temple at its feet
6. The valley temple of Khafre with its granite pillars (ask)

EASY TO MISS

- The Sphinx's missing nose was not shot by Napoleon's army. Drawings from 1737 already show it missing.
- Look at the north face of Menkaure's pyramid: a vertical gash. In 1196, a ruler tried to dismantle it, gave up after months, and left the scar.
- Small queens' pyramids stand beside each big one. Count them.
- The workers' town and cemetery lie south of the Sphinx. They are excavation sites, usually closed, but you can look in their direction.



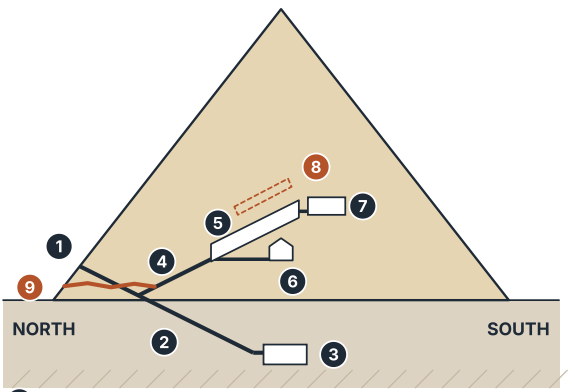
The Pyramid of Khafre at Giza, with the original smooth casing still on its summit. Photo: Jerome Bon from Paris, France, CC BY 2.0



The Pyramid of Menkaure at Giza in May 2015. Photo: MusikAnimal, CC BY-SA 4.0

Inside the Great Pyramid

Schematic cross-section, north to south. Not to scale.



1. **Original entrance,** north face, ~17 m up
2. **Descending Passage**
3. **Unfinished underground chamber**
4. **Ascending Passage**
5. **Grand Gallery**
6. **Queen's Chamber**
7. **King's Chamber**
8. **Big Void** (ScanPyramids, found 2017, ~30 m long)
9. **Al-Mamun's tunnel,** c. AD 820: today's way in

Interior visit is not part of your programme

DON'T MISS

A single block at Khufu's base. Each block weighs about 2.5 tonnes on average. There are over two million. Stand next to one.

Khafre's casing. Near the top of Khafre's pyramid you can still see the smooth limestone skin that once covered all of them.

The Sphinx from the side. About 73 m long and carved out of the rock of the plateau itself. Walk around it to see its body.

The Dream Stele. Between the Sphinx's paws is a stone telling how prince Thutmose IV fell asleep in its shadow and dreamed that if he cleared the sand, he would become king.

Three sizes, three kings. Khufu is the biggest, Menkaure the smallest. Khafre looks the biggest because it stands on higher ground.

ASK THE GUIDE

- What did the workers eat, and where did they sleep?
- Where did the stone come from, and how was it brought?
- What did the Sphinx look like when it was painted?
- What did the ScanPyramids team find inside Khufu's pyramid in 2017?
- Where was Khufu's boat found, and where is it now?

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find three differences between Khufu's and Khafre's pyramids (angle, casing, setting, size).

Estimate. Khufu's pyramid has about 2.3 million blocks. If a block was set every two minutes, working 10 hours a day, how many years would that take? What does that tell you about the size of the workforce?

TIPS

- Camels, horses and photographers will approach. A clear 'La, shukran' is enough. Agree any price before you start.
- The Great Pyramid's interior is not part of your programme. The diagram shows what is inside.

DAYS 4 TO 9

The Nile cruise

Seven nights on the M/S Monaco. The river runs north, so you sail upstream to Aswan and drift back down.

The Nile cruise



Day by day

4. Board the boat in Luxor
5. Luxor sights, then sail to Esna; overnight near Edfu
   - temple visit on land
6. Edfu temple, then sail via Kom Ombo (temple) to Aswan
   - temple visit on land
7. Aswan: High Dam, Philae, felucca
   - temple visit on land
8. Sail back via Kom Ombo to Edfu
9. Sail via the Esna lock to Luxor
10. Luxor west bank
    - temple visit on land
11. Fly home

Temple visit on land
Esna lock
~40 km along the river
Luxor to Aswan: ~215 km

Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL)
Land cover © ESA WorldCover 2021 (CC BY 4.0)

THE PLAN

Sailing. Luxor to Esna, Edfu, Kom Ombo and Aswan on the way up. Back down to Edfu, through the Esna lock, to Luxor.

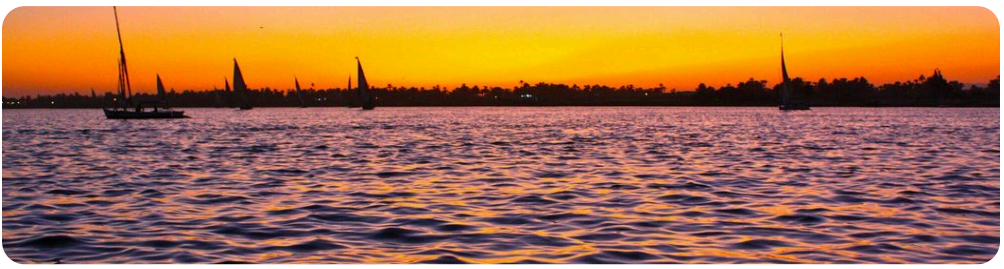
On land. Luxor Temple and Karnak, Edfu, Kom Ombo, High Dam, Philae, then the west bank of Luxor on Day 10.

On deck. Sailing hours are for rest, reading and the river. The Nile life page tells you what to look for.

DAYS 5, 8 AND 9 · ON THE RIVER

The Nile days and the Esna lock

Long sailing days are the best way to understand Egypt: a green strip between two deserts.



Sunrise over the Nile at Luxor, with the silhouettes of feluccas on the water. Photo: Kyle Taylor, CC BY 2.0

SAILING TIMES (PROGRAMME)	THE LOCK	LOOK FOR
Day 5 about 3 h, Day 6 about 5 h, Day 8 about 7 h, Day 9 about 4 h	**Esna, built by British engineers in the early 1900s**	**Where green meets sand**

THE STORY · WIND NORTH, CURRENT SOUTH

The Nile flows north. The wind blows mostly from the north. So a boat can sail upstream with its sail up, and float downstream with its sail down. The Egyptians noticed, and their hieroglyph for 'south' is a boat with a sail, and for 'north' a boat without one. Egypt's whole geography is in that pair of signs. At Esna, the river is held back by a barrage and boats wait their turn in the lock, often for hours. Small trading boats tie up beside the cruise ships, and the sellers throw their goods up to the decks.

DON'T MISS

The green line. Look for the exact line where irrigated fields stop and desert begins. On this bank, you could stand with one foot on each.

The lock. A real piece of engineering you will wait inside. Watch the gate open and close.

Life along the banks. Water buffalo, farmers in galabeyas, children waving, sugar cane, palm groves, small boats.

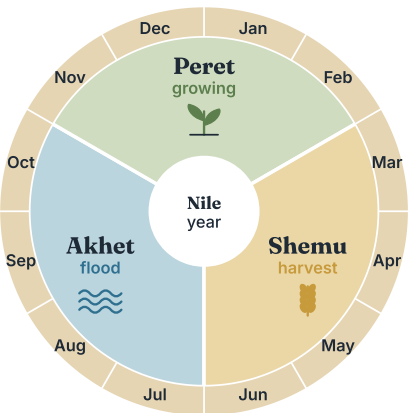
Birds. Egrets, herons, kingfishers and hoopoes. The sun deck at dusk is the best seat.

EASY TO MISS

- Look for the shaduf, a pole with a bucket and counterweight, used to lift water for thousands of years.
- Some village houses in Upper Egypt are painted with scenes of the pilgrimage to Mecca. It is a local tradition.
- The ancient Egyptians had three seasons: flood, growing, harvest. The dam ended the flood.
- At dusk, the temples are lit up. Watch the shoreline as you pass.

The three seasons of the Nile

The ancient Egyptian farming year.



Akhet, flood (about July to November)
The river covers the fields and leaves rich black mud.

Peret, growing (about November to March)
The water goes down; farmers sow and the crops grow.

Shemu, harvest (about March to July)
Crops are cut and the river is at its lowest.

The Aswan High Dam (1970) ended the yearly flood.

WALK IT

1. Day 5: leave Luxor, sail about 3 h to Esna
2. Esna lock: a wait, then the gates
3. Evening: moor near Edfu
4. Day 8: long sail back (about 7 h), past Kom Ombo
5. Day 9: Edfu to Luxor via the Esna lock

ASK THE GUIDE

- How high did the river used to rise before the dam?
- What crops grow along this bank?
- How does the lock work, and who runs it?
- Why do you have so many boats on the Nile?

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Make a deck list of ten things you see in one hour: a bird, a boat type, a crop, a house colour, an animal. Compare lists at dinner.

Estimate. On Day 8 the boat sails about 7 hours from Aswan towards Edfu, roughly 110 km by river. What is its average speed in km/h? Does the current help or slow it?

TIPS

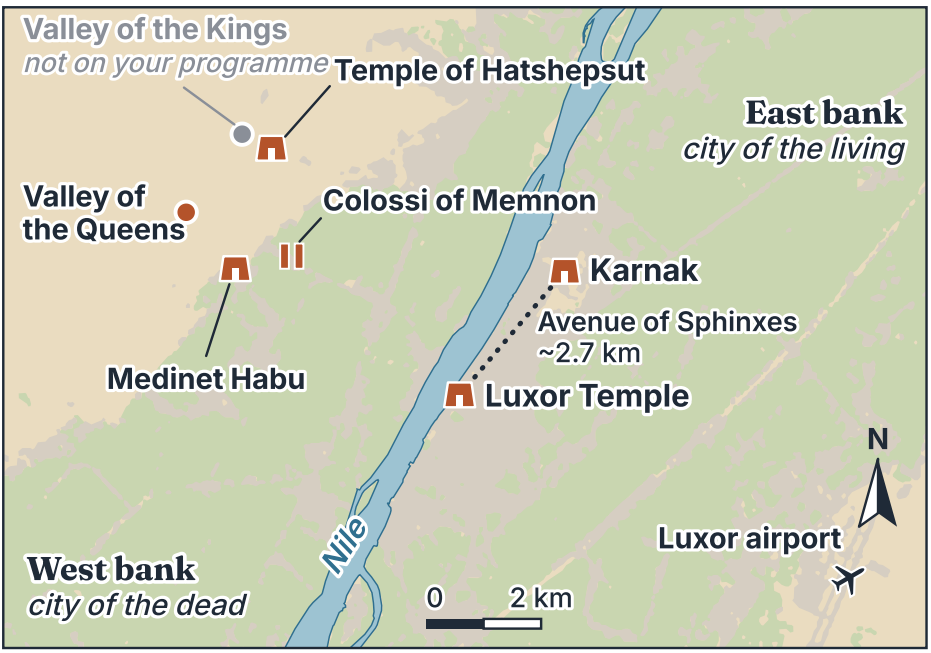
- Take a hat and a long-sleeved shirt for the sun deck. The breeze hides the sun.
- Cabins, pool and sun deck are the family's time to rest. Plan one slow hour on each sailing day.

DAYS 5 AND 10

Luxor: two banks

The east bank is the city of the living: temples of Luxor and Karnak. The west bank is the city of the dead: tombs and mortuary temples.

Luxor, two banks



Map data © OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL)
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THE PLAN

Day 5, east bank. Luxor Temple and Karnak, joined by the Avenue of Sphinxes, about 2.7 km.

Day 10, west bank. Valley of the Queens, Colossi of Memnon, Medinet Habu and the temple of Hatshepsut.

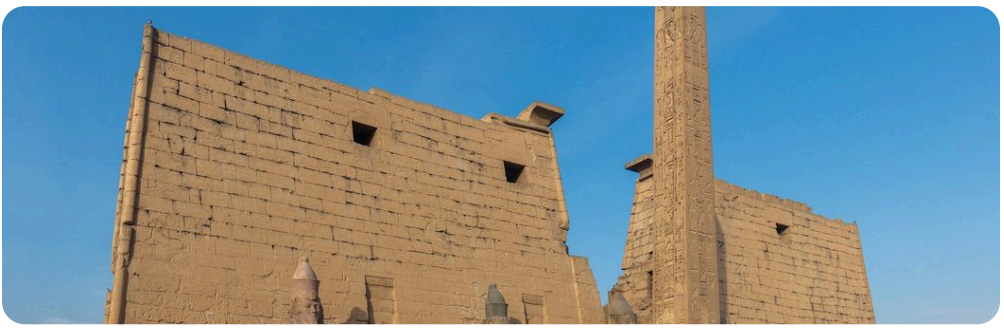
Not in the printed programme. The Valley of the Kings. Ask the representative whether it fits on Day 10.

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DAY 5 MORNING · EAST BANK

Luxor Temple

A temple in the middle of a modern city, with a working mosque on top of it.



The first pylon of Luxor Temple with the obelisk of Ramesses II and the statues of Ramesses II at the entrance.
Photo: Diego Delso, CC BY-SA 4.0

PLAN	BUILT	JOB
about 1.5 h	Amenhotep III (c. 1390 BC), Ramesses II (c. 1250 BC)	The place where the god Amun came to visit, once a year

A Road Between Two Temples
Short · 6 min

THE STORY · THE OBELISK THAT LIVES IN PARIS

Two obelisks once stood at this gate. In 1829 Egypt's ruler Muhammad Ali offered one to France. It was lowered onto a purpose-built ship, sailed down the Nile and across the Mediterranean, and in 1836 it was raised in the Place de la Concorde, where it stands today. The other one stayed here. When you see the single obelisk at Luxor, you are looking at the twin of one you may have walked past in Paris. Each year, in the flood season, the statue of Amun was carried here from Karnak, along the avenue or on the river, for a festival called Opet.

WALK IT

1. The Avenue of Sphinxes and the pylon: obelisk and colossi
2. Court of Ramesses II (the angled one)
3. Colonnade of Amenhotep III: the tall papyrus columns
4. Sun Court and the inner halls
5. The Roman painted chamber and the shrine of Alexander (ask)
6. Up above: the Abu el-Haggag mosque on the court

DON'T MISS

The obelisk and the seated colossi. The pylon is 24 m high and shows Ramesses II at the Battle of Kadesh. His name is cut on almost everything.

The colonnade. Fourteen columns shaped like papyrus buds, each about 19 m tall. They line the road that the god's procession followed.

The mosque above the court. Abu el-Haggag has stood here for about 800 years. Egypt's layers (temple, church, mosque) are all in one view.

The Opet reliefs. Scenes along the colonnade show the procession: boats, priests, music. A film storyboard in stone.

EASY TO MISS

- The court of Ramesses II is askew compared with the rest of the temple. He angled it to line up with older shrines.
- In the Roman chamber, a painted ceiling covers the old reliefs. Soldiers once used this room.
- Count the seated colossi at the pylon and the standing ones in the court. Some are missing.
- Each year the Abu el-Haggag festival carries boats through the streets, a living echo of Opet.

ASK THE GUIDE

- What happened in this temple at the Opet festival, day by day?
- Why was the court built crooked?
- How was the obelisk moved to Paris, and how did Egypt feel about it?
- How can a mosque stand on a temple without damaging it?
- Where does the Avenue of Sphinxes start, and can we see a piece of it?

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find the Battle of Kadesh on the pylon. How do you tell Ramesses II from his soldiers? Think about size, position and what each one is doing.

Debate. Should France keep the Paris obelisk? Make the case in two sentences each, one for keeping it and one for returning it.

TIPS

- Morning light is gentle, and the temple is calm. Read the colonnade scenes at a slow pace.
- Evenings, the temple is lit up. If you have the energy on another evening, ask the boat's reception.

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DAY 5 · EAST BANK

Karnak

The biggest religious complex humans ever built. Thirty kings added to it over about 2,000 years.



A row of ram-headed sphinxes of Amun lining the processional way in front of the first pylon of Karnak. Photo: Diego Delso, CC BY-SA 4.0

PLAN	BUILT	HEADLINER
about 2 to 2.5 h	from about 1950 BC to Roman times	The Great Hypostyle Hall: 134 columns

▶ **Karnak: Hall of Giants**
Short · 6 min

▶ **Ramesses II: The Greatest Publicist in History**
Story · 11 min

THE STORY · THE HALL OF GIANTS

Step into the Great Hypostyle Hall. 134 stone columns stand in 16 rows. The twelve down the middle are about 21 m tall and their tops open like papyrus flowers. The side columns are shorter, so a band of windows at the top lets in a stripe of light. Seti I began the hall and his son Ramesses II finished it, about 3,300 years ago. It was once roofed and painted in bright colours. You are walking through a forest of stone plants, designed to feel like the first marsh at the beginning of the world.

EASY TO MISS

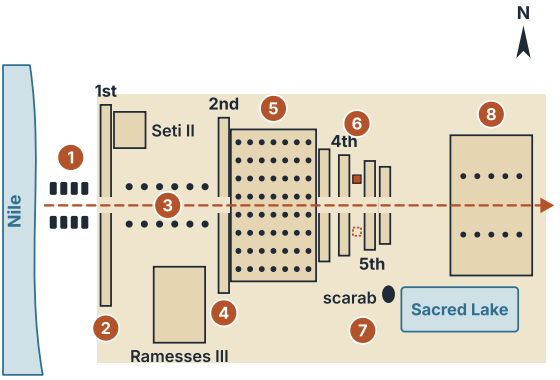
- On the First Pylon's back face, look for a long ramp of mud brick, thought to be a leftover construction ramp.
- A long inscription at Karnak records the peace treaty that Ramesses II made with the Hittites. Ask the guide where it is.
- The Hypostyle Hall's outer walls carry battle scenes of Seti I and Ramesses II.
- Thutmose III walled in Hatshepsut's obelisks. Look for traces of where the wall stood.

ASK THE GUIDE

- Which king built which part? Can you show us the oldest piece?
- How was the roof placed on 21 m columns?
- Why was the Great Court's pylon never finished?
- What did priests do here every day?
- What is the Treaty of Kadesh, and where is it on the wall?

Karnak: the main axis, west to east

Schematic, not to scale. North is up.



The axis leads from the Nile inland, west to east.

1. **Avenue of ram-headed sphinxes**
2. **First Pylon**
3. **Great Court:** Kiosk of Taharqa in the middle, Seti II to the north, Ramesses III to the south
4. **Second Pylon**
5. **Great Hypostyle Hall:** 134 columns
6. **Obelisks** between the 4th and 5th Pylons
7. **Sacred Lake and giant scarab,** south of the axis
8. **Festival Hall of Thutmose III**

Obelisks: Hatshepsut's still stands, a fallen one lies beside it.
The walking route is up to your guide, this shows the logic.

WALK IT

1. Avenue of ram-headed sphinxes
2. First Pylon, then the Great Court
3. The Kiosk of Taharqa: one column left
4. Great Hypostyle Hall
5. The obelisks of Hatshepsut and Thutmose I
6. Sacred Lake and the giant scarab
7. Festival Hall of Thutmose III (if time)

DON'T MISS

The ram sphinxes. The ram is Amun's animal. Between the paws of each one is a tiny statue of a king.

The Hypostyle Hall. Stand in the middle row and look up. Notice the windows and the leftover paint on the architraves.

Hatshepsut's obelisk. About 30 m of one piece of red granite from Aswan, the tallest still standing in Egypt. The tip was once covered in gold.

The Sacred Lake. Priests washed here before ceremonies. Locals say seven laps around it bring luck. Ask the guide what it promises.

The giant scarab. A granite beetle on a pedestal beside the lake, a symbol of the sun's rebirth.

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find three ways a column can be decorated: papyrus, lotus, carved figures. Which is which?

Estimate. The tall columns in the hall are about 21 m high. If a person is 1.7 m, how many people stacked up reach the top?

TIPS

- Go early or late: better light, fewer crowds. Little shade, so hat, water and sun cream.
- Sound and Light is optional (60 EUR per person, in French, per your programme).

DAY 6 MORNING · BY HORSE CARRIAGE FROM THE BOAT

Edfu, the Temple of Horus

The best-preserved temple in Egypt, and the clearest textbook of how a temple works.



The front of the pylon of the Temple of Horus at Edfu, with the gateway between the two towers covered in large reliefs. Photo: Vyacheslav Argenberg, CC BY 4.0

PLAN	BUILT	GOD
about 1.5 h	237 to 57 BC, under the Ptolemies	Horus, the falcon-headed sky god

▶ **Edfu: Reading a Temple Like a Book**
Short · 6 min

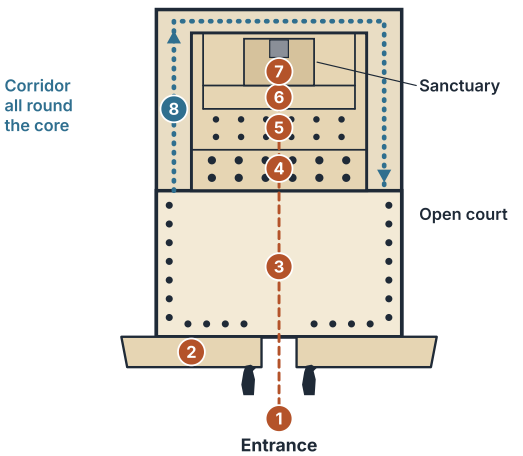
▶ **Horus and Set: The Longest Lawsuit in Heaven**
Story · 10 min

THE STORY · HATHOR COMES TO VISIT

Every year, in high summer, a statue of the goddess Hathor was lifted onto a boat at her temple at Dendera, north of Luxor, and carried upriver to Edfu, a journey of days. There she met the god Horus, and they were married again in a festival called the Beautiful Meeting. Crowds lined the river and the temple walls carry the stories. The temple itself was buried in sand and houses until the 1860s, when it was dug out. Because of that, it is nearly complete.

Edfu temple: the visit in 8 stops

Plan, entrance at the bottom. Not to scale.



Calèche drop-off and ticket gate: ask the guide

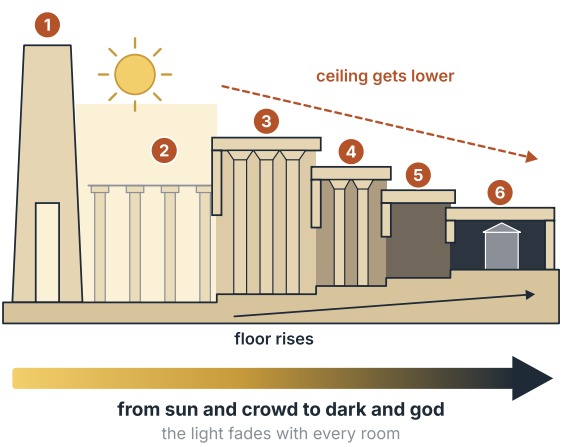
1. **Granite falcons of Horus** at the gate
2. **Pylon:** the king smiting enemies
3. **Open court** with its colonnade
4. **First hall of columns**
5. **Second hall**
6. **Offering hall**
7. **Sanctuary** with the granite shrine
8. **Corridor:** Horus fights Set on the walls

WALK IT

1. Horse-carriage ride from the quay to the temple
2. The granite falcons and the great pylon
3. The open court with columns on three sides
4. The first hall of columns (hypostyle)
5. Second hall, the offering hall, the sanctuary
6. The sanctuary: the granite shrine
7. The walkway round the outside: Horus against Set (ask)

Into the temple, step by step

Long section, Edfu as the example. Not to scale.



1. **Pylon and gate:** the giant front door
2. **Sun court:** open to the sky, the brightest part
3. **First hall of columns:** shade, a stone forest
4. **Second hall:** smaller and darker
5. **Offering hall:** food and gifts for the god
6. **Sanctuary:** the god's shrine, highest and darkest

DON'T MISS

The falcon of Horus. A granite falcon in a crown stands at the gate. The god protecting the entrance.

The pylon relief. A giant king grabbing his enemies by the hair. It is a symbolic picture, repeated on every pylon, and it keeps order.

The darkness gets deeper. As you walk inwards, the floor rises, the ceiling lowers and the light fades. That is by design.

The granite shrine. In the sanctuary a polished stone shrine is much older than the temple. It was reused from the earlier building.

The walls are full of text. Edfu has more hieroglyphic text than almost any other temple: festival rules, building records, a list of the temple library.

EASY TO MISS

- Look at the faces on the reliefs: many have been chiselled off by early Christians, who lived in and around the temple.
- The ceilings in some halls are black from old cooking fires.
- Look for the tall grooves in the pylon. Flagpoles with banners were set in them.
- Small rooms off the main halls were storerooms, a treasury and even a 'library' of papyrus scrolls.

ASK THE GUIDE

- How do we read the sequence of rooms, and where would the priests have walked?
- Why were the Ptolemies, who were Greek, building a temple in this style?
- Can we see the walkway around the outside with the scenes of Horus and Set?
- How did the temple stay so complete?
- What is the Beautiful Meeting?

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find a scene where the king gives something to a god. What is he holding, and what is the god holding?

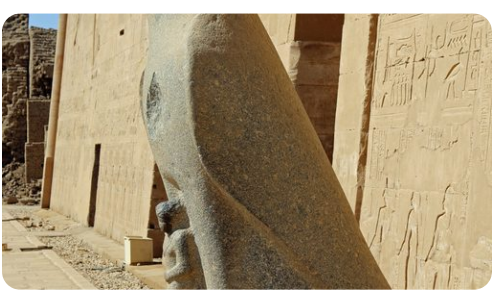
Estimate. The pylon is about 36 m high. If a floor is 3 m, how many floors? Compare it with a building near home.

TIPS

- The carriage ride is part of the experience. A small tip for the driver is normal. Ask the guide what is usual.
- Early morning is quieter. The stone is cool and the light enters the court from the side.



The open court of the Temple of Horus at Edfu with its colonnade and the pylon behind. Photo: Rémih, CC BY-SA 3.0



The granite statue of Horus as a falcon standing beside the pylon of the Temple of Horus at Edfu. Photo: Marc Ryckaert, CC BY-SA 4.0

DAY 6 AFTERNOON · ON A BEND OF THE RIVER

Kom Ombo

A temple with twin doors: one half for a crocodile god and one half for a falcon god.



Columns with floral capitals and architraves in the double temple of Sobek and Haroeris at Kom Ombo, against a blue sky. Photo: Carole Raddato, CC BY-SA 2.0

PLAN	BUILT	GODS
about 1 h	from about 180 BC, under the Ptolemies	Sobek (crocodile) and Haroeris (Horus the Elder)

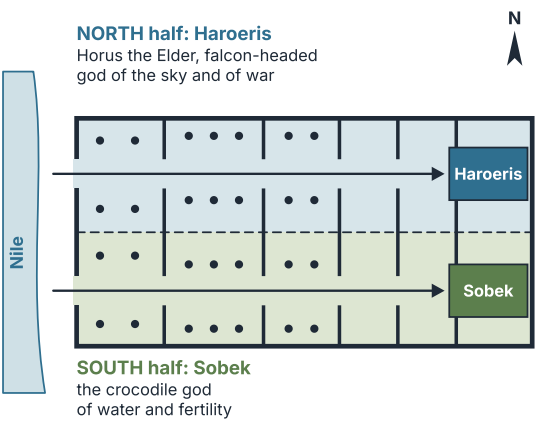
Kom Ombo: Twin Gods
Short · 5 min

THE STORY · TWO GODS, ONE ROOF

Most temples serve one god. This one has two of everything: two entrances, two halls, two sanctuaries, side by side. The northern half belongs to Haroeris, a form of the falcon god Horus, and the southern half to Sobek, the crocodile god of the river. The temple sits on a bend of the Nile where sandbanks were once covered in basking crocodiles. Sobek was feared and honoured. Mummified crocodiles were left here as offerings.

Kom Ombo: one temple, two gods

Plan. Not to scale.



twin doors, twin halls, twin sanctuaries

The temple faces the Nile. Both gods share the outer walls. Dashed line: the centre line between the two halves.

WALK IT

1. Arrive at the temple on its bluff above the river
2. The courtyard and the double entrance
3. The two halls of columns
4. The two sanctuaries at the back
5. The walls on the outside: the medical instruments
6. The Crocodile Museum, if included (ask)

DON'T MISS

The double plan. North and south halves mirror each other. Walk both and compare.

Sobek reliefs. A man with a crocodile's head, receiving offerings. Look for the crocodile on a shrine.

The medical instruments. A relief on the outer wall shows what look like medical tools: a lancet, a sponge, forceps. Historians are careful about what exactly it shows.

The calendar. Texts on the wall list the festivals of the year.

The view. The temple is placed to catch the river bend. Turn round and look at the Nile.

EASY TO MISS

- Look for a round stone well with a stair: it is the Nilometer, used to measure the flood.
- Crocodile mummies of all sizes were found nearby. The Crocodile Museum next door shows some.
- The columns have capitals shaped like papyrus and lotus. Notice how the colours remain on a few.
- A small chapel of Hathor was used to store crocodile mummies.

ASK THE GUIDE

- Why two gods in one temple?
- How do we know which half is which?
- What does the medical relief really show?
- How did people look after and mummify crocodiles?
- Did Sobek protect people from crocodiles or did people fear him?

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find a mirrored pair of scenes, one on each side of the temple. What small differences can you spot?

Debate. A crocodile god and a falcon god sharing a temple: who is likely to have been more popular with farmers, and why?

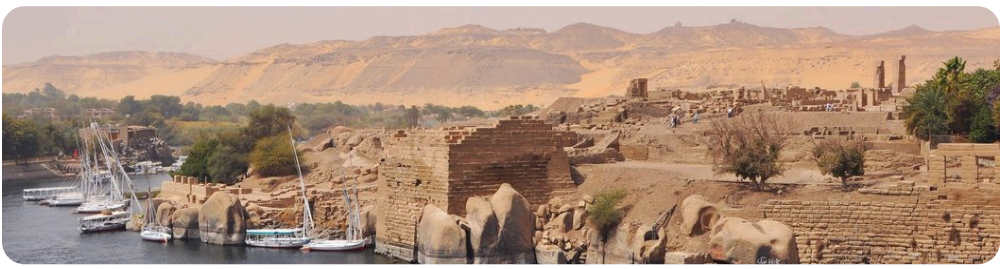
TIPS

- A short stop at a lovely time of day. The temple can be crowded by cruise groups, so move along the walls.
- The Crocodile Museum is a separate building. Your programme does not list it, so ask.

DAY 7 · THE FIRST CATARACT

Aswan: High Dam, felucca and Elephantine

The place where the Nile was stopped, and one of the loveliest river views in Egypt.



Elephantine Island at Aswan with ancient ruins on the rocky shore and feluccas moored along the Nile. Photo: Marc Ryckaert (MJJR), CC BY 3.0

PLAN	DAM	LAKE
High Dam about 45 min, felucca about 1 h	built 1960 to 1970, about 3.8 km long, 111 m high	Lake Nasser, about 500 km long

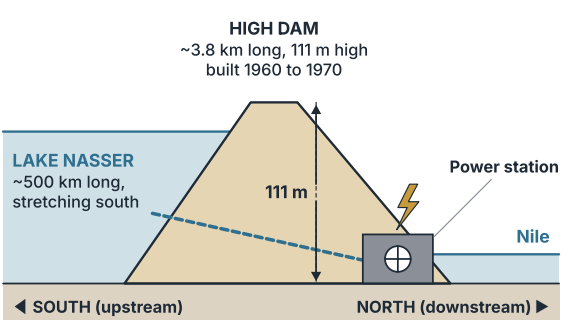
Isis and the Temple That Would Not Drown
Story · 10 min

THE STORY · THE LAKE THAT MOVED TWO TEMPLES

For thousands of years, the Nile rose every summer and fell every autumn. In 1970, the High Dam ended that. It stored the water in a lake nearly 500 km long, gave Egypt power and protected it against drought and flood. But the lake covered Nubia, a region with its own language, villages and temples. Around 100,000 people were moved and a worldwide appeal helped to save the temples, including Philae and Abu Simbel. You will see one of them tomorrow.

The Aswan High Dam

Simple cross-section. Not to scale.



the Nile flows north to Cairo and the sea

Philae and Abu Simbel were moved because of this lake.

WALK IT

1. High Dam: a viewpoint over the lake and the dam wall
2. The Lotus monument beside the dam
3. Philae temple (next page)
4. Felucca on the Nile around Elephantine
5. Elephantine: look for the Nilometer and old town

DON'T MISS

The dam wall. Three kilometres of rock and earth. On one side, a lake. On the other, the old river.

The felucca. A wooden sailing boat with a triangle sail. The captain uses wind and current, as people have here for thousands of years.

Elephantine Island. Named 'elephant' either from the ivory trade or from the shape of the granite boulders in the river.

The Nile cataract rocks. Dark granite boulders in the river mark the First Cataract, the old southern border of Egypt.

EASY TO MISS

- Granite here is the stone of obelisks. Look at the pink and black rocks on the shore.
- The Nubian houses on the west bank are painted in bright colours.
- Look for the Nilometer steps on Elephantine, used to measure the river's height.
- Birdwatchers love this stretch. Look for egrets on the rocks.

ASK THE GUIDE

- What did the dam give Egypt, and what did it take away?
- Where did the Nubians go, and what do they say about it today?
- How did the flood work before the dam?
- What does the captain do to sail against the wind?

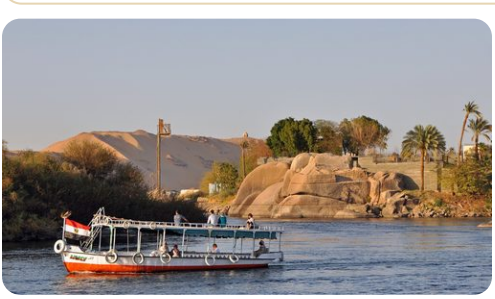
LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find rock that is not sandstone. What colour is it? Where have you seen it earlier in the trip?

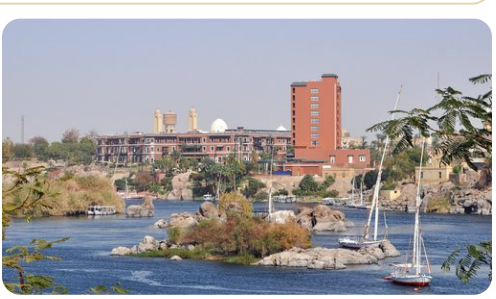
Estimate. The dam is about 3.8 km long. How long would it take to walk across at a normal pace?

TIPS

- On the felucca, sit as the captain asks. Sunscreen and a hat are needed because there is no shade.
- Swimming from the boat is not recommended. Keep phones on lanyards or in bags.



The Nile at Aswan with a passenger boat in front of granite boulders and palms on Elephantine Island. Photo: Marc Ryckaert (MJJR), CC BY 3.0



The Nile at Aswan with the Old Cataract Hotel on the far bank and sailing boats in the foreground. Photo: Marc Ryckaert (MJJR), CC BY 3.0

DAY 7 MORNING · BY MOTORBOAT TO AGILKIA ISLAND

Philae, the temple that moved

The sanctuary of Isis, dismantled block by block and rebuilt on higher ground in the 1970s.



The first pylon and the colonnade of the Temple of Isis on Agilkia Island, the relocated Philae temple complex. Photo: Vyacheslav Argenberg, CC BY 4.0

PLAN	BUILT	MOVED
about 1.5 h	from about 380 BC to Roman times	1972 to 1980, to Agilkia Island

Isis and the Temple That Would Not Drown
Story · 10 min

THE STORY · THE LAST HIEROGLYPHS

Philae was the last of Egypt's temples to close. While Rome became Christian, pilgrims kept coming here to honour Isis, the mother goddess. The last dated hieroglyphic inscription we know of, from 24 August AD 394, is carved here. The temple was closed in the sixth century. Fifteen centuries later, the rising waters behind the dams threatened it again. Engineers built a wall around the island, pumped it dry, cut the temples into blocks, numbered them and rebuilt them on a neighbouring island that was shaped to look like the original.

EASY TO MISS

- Look closely at the reliefs on the pylons: some have Christian crosses carved on them.
- The Birth House walls show Isis nursing the baby Horus.
- Graffiti from 1799: French soldiers of Napoleon's expedition left an inscription at Philae. Ask the guide.
- Look for the Nilometer at the foot of the island.

ASK THE GUIDE

- Who was Isis, and why did her worship spread to Rome?
- Where is the old Philae island today?
- How were the blocks numbered and moved?
- What did the temple look like in colour?
- Where is the French inscription from 1799?

Philae: the visit in order

Route diagram. Not to scale.

The original Philae island is under the lake.
The temples stand on Agilkia, moved there in the 1970s.

1. **Boat to Agilkia Island**
   a short motorboat ride from the landing
2. **Kiosk of Nectanebo, west colonnade**
   the first building, then a long row of columns
3. **First Pylon**
   the great gateway of the temple of Isis
4. **Court and the Birth House (Mammisi)**
   it celebrates the birth of Horus, son of Isis
5. **Second Pylon**
   the inner gateway
6. **Hall and sanctuary of Isis**
   the darkest, most sacred rooms
7. **Gate of Hadrian, Osiris rooms**
   a Roman gate; rooms for Osiris, Isis's husband
8. **Trajan's Kiosk by the water**
   the last view, the classic photo

WALK IT

1. Motorboat ride from the landing to the island
2. The Kiosk of Nectanebo and the west colonnade
3. The First Pylon with the giant king figures
4. The court and the Birth House (Mammisi)
5. The Second Pylon and the hall
6. The inner sanctuary of Isis
7. The Gate of Hadrian and the Osiris rooms
8. Trajan's Kiosk by the water, the last view

DON'T MISS

The boat approach. The temple rises from the water. This is the view travellers painted in the nineteenth century.

The First Pylon. Huge figures of a king smiting enemies in front of gods. The figures are scratched with early Christian crosses.

The Gate of Hadrian. The last hieroglyphic inscription is nearby. Ask the guide where, and for the relief of the god of the Nile in his cave.

Trajan's Kiosk. A Roman kiosk by the water, never finished. It is on every postcard.

The numbered blocks. Ask whether any building marks from the 1970s relocation are visible on the stones.

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find a Christian cross carved on a temple wall. What does it tell you about how the temple was used after its gods left?

Estimate. Tens of thousands of blocks were moved. Say 40,000. If a crew moved 20 per day, how long would the job take? What would you want on your crew?

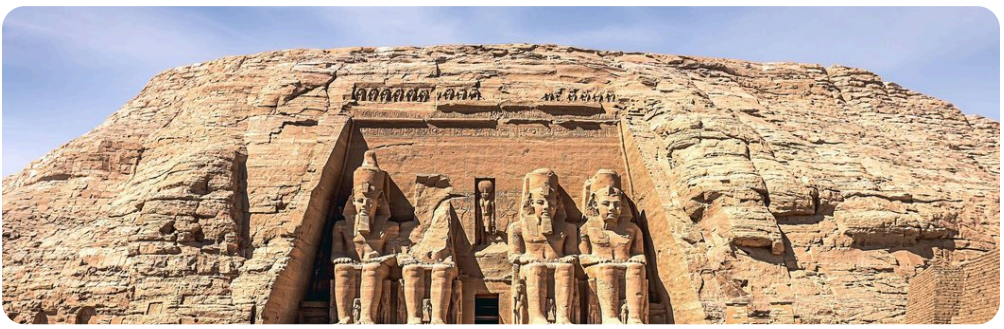
TIPS

- Boats are small and the sun is bright. Hat, sunscreen, water.
- The Sound and Light show at Philae is optional (65 EUR per person, in French, as listed in your programme).

DAY 8 · OPTIONAL EXCURSION, EARLY START

Abu Simbel (optional)

Four colossal statues of Ramesses II carved into a cliff, 280 km south of Aswan.



The facade of the Great Temple of Ramesses II at Abu Simbel with its four seated colossi. Photo: Yasser.mahmoud, CC BY-SA 4.0

OPTION 1	OPTION 2	BUILT
By coach, 130 EUR per person (programme price)	By plane, 415 EUR per person (programme price)	about 1264 to 1244 BC, Ramesses II

Isis and the Temple That Would Not Drown
Story · 10 min

THE STORY · THE SUN THAT VISITS TWICE A YEAR

Ramesses II had a temple cut into the cliff so that on two days in the year the rising sun reaches deep inside and lights the statues in the sanctuary. The dates are about 22 February and 22 October. After the temple was cut into blocks in the 1960s and moved to higher ground, the dates shifted by a day. Your Day 8 is 28 October, so you will not see it. You will still see four seated colossi, each about 20 m high, and a smaller temple for his queen Nefertari.

WALK IT

1. Early start (by coach, the road convoy leaves in the dark)
2. The facade of the Great Temple
3. Inside: the pillared hall and the sanctuary
4. The Small Temple of Nefertari and Hathor
5. A look at how the temples were moved

DON'T MISS

The facade. Four seated colossi of Ramesses II. Count the small figures at their feet: they are his family.

The pillared hall. Statues of the king as Osiris line the hall. The walls show the Battle of Kadesh.

The Small Temple. One of the rare temples where a queen is shown at the same size as the king.

The dome behind. Behind the facade, the hill is man-made. It is a concrete dome that holds the relocated temple.

EASY TO MISS

- Look at the graffiti on one of the colossi's legs: Greek soldiers from 600 BC wrote their names.
- The head of one colossus fell in antiquity and lies at its feet.
- Ramesses II's face is carved similar to his statues elsewhere. Compare with Luxor and Karnak.

ASK THE GUIDE

- How were the temples cut and moved?
- Why did Ramesses II build so far south?
- What do the figures at the colossi's feet represent?
- How did they calculate the sun alignment?

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find the line in the rock where the temples were cut and rejoined. Can you spot any seams?

Debate. A temple was moved and its sun alignment shifted by a day. Is it still the same temple?

TIPS

- A suggestion: decide the evening before. The coach leaves very early, and the sailing that afternoon is long (about 7 hours).
- Children's prices are not listed in your programme. Ask the representative.



The facade of the Small Temple of Nefertari at Abu Simbel with its tall standing statues. Photo: Diego Delso, CC BY-SA 4.0



The pillared hall of the Great Temple at Abu Simbel with the standing Osiride statues of Ramesses II along the pillars. Photo: Diego Delso, CC BY-SA 4.0

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DAY 10 MORNING · WEST BANK

Valley of the Queens and the Colossi of Memnon

Painted tombs for queens and princes, and two giant statues that once made a sound at dawn.



Painted wall in the tomb of Nefertari (QV66) with a recumbent jackal and rows of hieroglyphs. Photo: Onceinawhile, CC BY-SA 4.0

PLAN	BUILT	LOOK FOR
Queens 1 h, Colossi 20 min	Tombs about 1250-1150 BC, statues about 1350 BC	Princes with a side-lock of youth

The Voice of the Statue
Short · 5 min

THE STORY · THE STATUE THAT SANG

In 27 BC an earthquake cracked one of the two statues of Amenhotep III. At dawn it began to give out a low sound, a kind of whistle or hum, probably as the cooled stone warmed in the morning sun. The Greeks said it was Memnon, son of the Dawn goddess, greeting his mother. Roman tourists came for centuries to hear it and scratched their names into the legs, including the emperor Hadrian in AD 130. Around AD 200 another emperor repaired the crack and the voice was lost.

WALK IT

1. Colossi of Memnon: a short photo stop on the way
2. Valley of the Queens: the visitor area
3. Tombs that are open that day (ask which)
4. Look for painted ceilings and the sides of doorways

DON'T MISS

The Colossi of Memnon. About 18 m tall, each cut from a single block. They guarded the entrance of a vast temple that is now fields.

The names on the legs. Zoom in on the stone: Roman visitors carved their names almost two thousand years ago.

A painted tomb. Colour survives in tombs better than in temples, because the light never got in. Ask which are open.

The princes. Children are shown with one braid at the side of the head, called the side-lock of youth.

EASY TO MISS

- Tombs of royal children are among the sweetest. Some princes died young and their father is shown leading them to the gods.
- The quartzite for the Colossi came from near modern Cairo, about 700 km away.
- The 'temple' behind the Colossi has almost completely vanished. The Memphis lesson again.
- Look at the ceilings: many are painted deep blue with yellow stars, to turn the tomb into a night sky.

ASK THE GUIDE

- Which tombs are open today, and are they included in our ticket?
- Who was buried here, and what do their names mean?
- Where is Nefertari's tomb, and can we see it?
- How did the statue make a sound, and what do scientists say?
- Where did the stone for the Colossi come from, and how did it travel?

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find a prince with the side-lock of youth. What is he doing with his hands?

Debate. A statue whistled at dawn and tourists came for 200 years. Then someone repaired it and the tourists left. Was the repair a mistake?

TIPS

- Open tombs change daily and extra tickets may apply. Ask the guide, and do not expect a promise.
- The Valley of the Kings is not on your printed programme. Ask if it is possible to add it. It sits beyond the same hills as Hatshepsut.

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DAY 10 · WEST BANK, TEMPLE OF RAMESSES III

Medinet Habu

A fortress-temple covered in carved battles, with more colour left on the walls than almost anywhere in Egypt.



The fortified high gate (migdol) at the entrance to the temple of Ramesses III at Medinet Habu. Photo: Marc Ryckaert (MJJR), CC BY 3.0

PLAN	BUILT	LOOK FOR
about 1.5 h	about 1170 BC, Ramesses III	Colour on the ceilings and columns

▶ The First Strike in History
Short · 5 min

THE STORY · THE FIRST STRIKE IN HISTORY

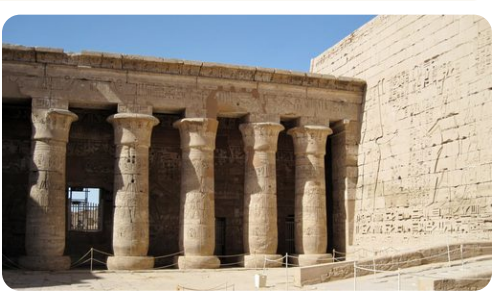
In the twenty-ninth year of Ramesses III, the workmen who cut and decorated the royal tombs went unpaid. Their rations of grain were late. They put their tools down, walked out to the temples near here, and sat down. A scribe wrote it all down on a papyrus. After some days, grain arrived. It is the first strike we have a written record of. The same king, who ruled a country under pressure from invaders, is shown on these walls winning every battle.

WALK IT

1. The high gate, built like a Syrian fortress
2. First Pylon and the first court
3. Second Pylon and the second court: look up
4. Walk around the outside north wall: the battle with the Sea Peoples
5. Look back at the pylons from the garden



The first pylon of the temple of Ramesses III at Medinet Habu. Photo: Olaf Tausch, CC BY 3.0



Colonnade in the first court of the temple of Ramesses III at Medinet Habu. Photo: Olaf Tausch, CC BY 3.0

DON'T MISS

The high gate. It is modelled on a fortified gate seen in Syria during Egyptian campaigns. Few Egyptian temples look like castles.

Colour on the ceiling. Blue skies, yellow stars, and vultures still shine in places. Imagine the whole temple like that.

The Sea Peoples reliefs. A land battle and a sea battle against groups of raiders who attacked Egypt about 1177 BC. Ask the guide to show you the ships.

Deep carving. The reliefs are deeply sunk into the stone. In side light they cast shadows and read like drawings.

EASY TO MISS

- In the second court, look for traces of a Christian church built among the temple columns in later centuries.
- The temple had a small palace attached, with a Window of Appearances where the king showed himself.
- Look for the line of royal statues standing as pillars, each in the form of the god of death and rebirth.
- Count how many times the king is smiting enemies. Do the poses ever differ?

ASK THE GUIDE

- What do we know about the Sea Peoples, and what remains uncertain?
- How did the workmen's strike end?
- How much of the original paint is left, and what keeps it alive?
- Why is the temple so heavily fortified?
- Why does Ramesses III copy Ramesses II so much?

LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find a ceiling with colour. List every colour you can see. Which ones would have been the most expensive?

Debate. A reliefs shows a king winning every battle. How would you know if he really did? What would you want to check?

TIPS

- The temple is wide and open. Walk the outside wall for the best battle reliefs.
- Colours fade in sunlight. Photograph the ceilings in shade, with no flash.

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DAY 10 · DEIR EL-BAHARI, WEST BANK

Temple of Hatshepsut

A temple of three terraces cut into a cliff, built by a woman who ruled as king.



The mortuary temple of Hatshepsut at Deir el-Bahari, with its terraces and central ramp against the limestone cliff.
Photo: Diego Delso, CC BY-SA 4.0

PLAN	BUILT	LOOK FOR
about 1.5 h	about 1470 BC, Hatshepsut and her steward Senenmut	The Punt expedition reliefs

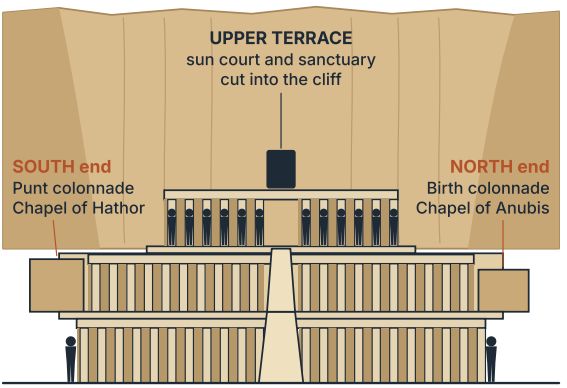
▶ **Hatshepsut: The King Who Wore a Beard**
Story · 10 min

THE STORY · A QUEEN WITH A KING'S BEARD

Hatshepsut began as the regent for a young stepson, Thutmose III. Within a few years she had herself crowned king and was shown in statues with the royal beard, kilt and crown. She ruled for about twenty years, and during that time trade flourished, and the temple at Deir el-Bahari was built. Later, many of her images were hacked out and her statues smashed. Historians still argue who did it, and why. The temple outlived her attackers.

Hatshepsut's temple: three terraces

Front view, looking west at the cliff. Not to scale.



LOWER TERRACE: colonnades with Osiride statues
A central ramp climbs from terrace to terrace

◀ SOUTH — you face west — NORTH ▶

Why this shape?
The temple copies the bowl of the cliff, and it faces east across the river towards Karnak.

WALK IT

1. From the car park: the whole temple against the cliff
2. Lower terrace: Osiride statues
3. Middle terrace, south: Punt reliefs and the Hathor chapel
4. Middle terrace, north: the divine birth reliefs and Anubis chapel
5. Upper terrace: the sun court (check access)
6. Look back: the axis points across the river to Karnak

DON'T MISS

The Punt expedition reliefs. Five ships sail to a faraway land for incense trees, gold, ebony, animals. The ships are carved in detail.

The Anubis chapel. A small chapel on the north side with the best colour: painted gods in a jewel-box room.

The ramps and symmetry. The temple is a calm series of terraces. It copies the curved cliff behind it.

Where her face was hacked. In several scenes the queen's figure was cut out. See the scars on the stone.

EASY TO MISS

- Next to the temple, to the south, lie the ruins of an older temple of Mentuhotep II. Hatshepsut copied that idea.
- Look at the Punt scenes for the large queen of Punt and the donkey that carries her. The artists enjoyed the details.
- The temple axis points across the river to Karnak's sanctuary.
- Hatshepsut planted incense trees brought back from Punt. Ask the guide to point out the tree pits.

ASK THE GUIDE

- Who defaced Hatshepsut's images, and when?
- Where was Punt, and how do we know?
- How did the builders get stone up the cliff?
- Who was Senenmut, and is there a tomb or a portrait?
- What is the difference between this and a tomb?

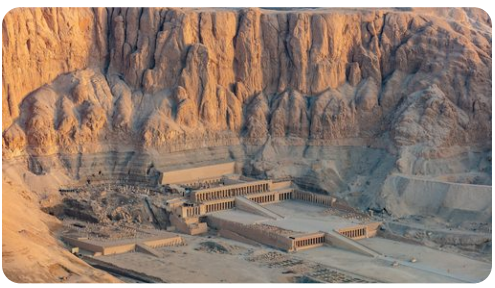
LOOK CLOSER

Look closer. Find a scene with a ship. Count the oars, sails and cargo. What would you carry home from a far land?

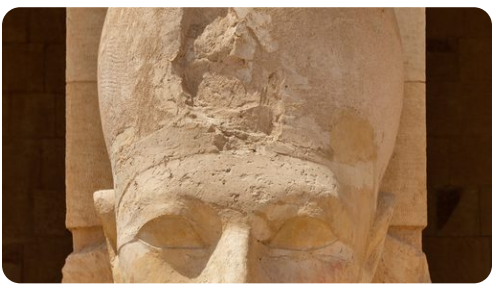
Debate. If a ruler is so successful, why would people erase her name after she died? Give three possible reasons.

TIPS

- The temple is on a wide open slope. Hat, water, sun cream.
- Stairs and ramps. The upper terrace may be closed, so ask before you climb.



Aerial view at sunrise of the mortuary temple of Hatshepsut at Deir el-Bahari. Photo: Diego Delso, CC BY-SA 4.0



Osiride statue of Hatshepsut on a pillar of her mortuary temple at Deir el-Bahari. Photo: Diego Delso, CC BY-SA 4.0

DAY 11 · SAT 31 OCT

The way home

BEFORE YOU LEAVE THE BOAT

- Passports, tickets and boarding passes in one place.
- Chargers, torches and the tip envelopes.
- Check the safe, the cabin and the pool deck for forgotten things.
- Your flight leaves Luxor late morning. Your representative sets the time.

FIVE QUESTIONS FOR THE FLIGHT HOME

- Which room or place made you go quiet?
- Which story would you retell at school?
- Which thing did the guide say that you doubt?
- What would you like to look up?
- Where would you go back to first?

SOUVENIR THOUGHTS

Cotton, spices, alabaster and hand-woven things are common. Check that papyrus is real by looking for plant fibres. Prices are a conversation, not a sticker.

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